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PATNA IN FLIGHT The new airport terminal in Bihar's capital city

it, one where Modi inaugurated Patna's new airport terminal on May 29 and unveiled development projects valued at Rs 50,000 crore. But then, he also clearly hugged the political turf with a roadshow in Patna. As JD(U) leaders concede ruefully, even his Bikramganj speech spent enough time on shelling the Rashtriya Janata Dal-Congress, so it was hardly as if politics was off the plate. A marked omission, then.

This marked Modi's third visit here in 2025. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi too has made four visits. The stakes are clearly high. The RJD had topped the 2020 charts with 75 seats, one more than the BJP, but defections and bypolls have altered the tally. The BJP enters the fray as the single largest party, with 84 of 243 seats. The RJD holds 73; the JD(U) is in third place with 48 MLAs.

Bihar is the sole heartland state the BJP has never ruled on its own, and saffron strategists know they stand on the brink of rewriting that bit of history. Its 2020 vote share of 19.46 per cent, robust in itself, hides a deeper popularity: a 42.56 per cent vote share in the 110 seats it contested. A sizeable edge over the JD(U)'s 32.83 per cent across its 115, this is what validates the BJP's unspoken claim to the big prize: the CM's chair.

That profile gathers more weight if another fact is taken on board. See 2015 as an aberration on a pattern where the BJP and JD(U) had always contested in alliance. Each time, their vote share percentages in seats contested were nearly identical: 24.91/26.41 in February 2005, 35.64/37.14 in October 2005 and 39.56/38.77 in 2010. Discount the 2015 poll, where the JD(U)'s alliance with the RJD and the BJP's oppositionality would have skewed the numbers, and leap to 2020. The yawning gap of 9.73 percentage points that year, when Nitish was still at the top of his game, represented a real disruption of that equilibrium. The future that flashed in the tarot cards then is now within reach.

PLAN B COMES FIRST

The plan seems to be to play up the halo around Modi post Op. Sindoor, offsetting the perceptible erosion in Nitish's heft while not letting go of the bridge he offers to a core constituency of EBC, women and OBC voters. A BJP senior admits as much, saying his party is "unlikely to discard" Nitish before the polls owing to his loyal vote base, but may stake claim to the CM's post if the results favour saffron.

The faces one may see in the race in that event? Deputy CM Samrat Choudhary, a Koeri; and Union MoS Nityanand Rai, a Yadav, are seen as probables. There's also LJP scion Chirag Paswan: more a trojan horse than a dark horse. His push for more seats (and implicit self-projection as CM candidate) is being used to curtail Nitish's seat share, possibly to around 100. The real twist may be post-poll: if the BJP and its non-JD(U) pals alone secure a simple majority, or close. ■

Takeaways

- **Modi has pointedly avoided declaring Nitish as the NDA's chief ministerial face again**
- **That seems in sync with its plan to remove a big gap in its resume: solo power in Bihar**

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT'S 3,702 SQ. KM and 1.6 million residents form just 0.1 per cent each of India's land area and population. But Goa punches way above its weight in terms of political potboiler action. The latest: the acute mortification facing the Pramod Sawant government after one of its own ministers—a member of the ruling BJP at that—charged it with graft and malfeasance. What's worse, the impugned department, tribal welfare, is held by Sawant himself. Enough to speculate that something more than probity may be at stake.

A LITTLE FRIENDLY FIRE

The accuser—state arts and culture minister Govind Gaude—has held on for over a week in the cabinet after a public censure of his own government. That likely owes to his background: the MLA from Priol, north Goa, is from the Hindu Gauda community, a Scheduled Tribe. It's in that capacity that he was speaking at



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